

'BIG FOUR' SNAKES



KRAITS are nocturnal snakes, distinguishable by broad circles on the body and have an overall length of one to two metres.

The **RUSSEL'S VIPER** is identified by round scales. Its bite can lead to instant death and is responsible for thousands of fatalities.



The **COMMON COBRA** creates the impression of a hood by stretching out its neckbones and is usually nocturnal.

The **KING COBRA** is the largest venomous snake in the world with a length of more than three metres. It is usually active in daytime.



AIDING THE VICTIM

- First aid is crucial within four to six hours of attack
- The blood around the bite should be allowed to flow to reduce the effect of the poison.
- Anti-venom injections and intravenous solution should be administered.
- Avoid traditional medicine.

MISUNDERSTOOD

- One-tenth of all snake species are found in India.
- Most snakes do not attack unless provoked. About 90 per cent are non-poisonous.
- Non-poisonous snakes are usually responsible for bites.
- 'Friends of the farmers', snakes kill rodents and protect their crops. It is essential to make farmers understand this.



"Everyone enjoys the sight of pythons around fashion models' necks, but nobody objects."

K. K. SINGH, DIVISIONAL FOREST OFFICER, UTTAR PRADESH

"One can see pythons and cobras hanging around the necks of models. Everybody enjoys it, but nobody objects," says K.K. Singh, a divisional forest officer from Uttar Pradesh. In cities like Lucknow, Kanpur and Varanasi, defanged cobras and pythons can be rented at Rs 500 a day.

The diminishing number of cobras has spurred the authorities into bringing the animal under Schedule I of the Wildlife Act that proclaims its killing as a punishable offence. Says Louise, "In a country where snakes are revered and worshipped as an embodiment of Lord Shiva, it is a tragedy that they are being slaughtered."

The task is tough for both the Government and the conservationists. The Government has to upgrade its medical facilities and the conservationists have to educate the people about the dangers of using unscientific

methods while dealing with snakes. The government can start the upgrade of infrastructure by improving the supply of anti-venom drugs. At present, government hospitals in rural areas in Uttar Pradesh get only five ampoules of anti-venom drugs while 20 are required for a single snake bite. Refrigeration facilities are needed in hospitals for the storage of liquid medicines but frequent power cuts make refrigeration difficult. "The supply of power in villages is very poor. We hardly get eight hours of electricity in a day," laments a doctor.

Taking note of this emergency, Singh organised a two-day workshop in Lakhimpur Kheri district recently. It was attended by Louise and Dr Asaf Ali, who is working on a snake bite treatment project with Fortis India. The workshop drew attention to the fact that it was the nonchalant attitude

of the authorities and of the people which was at the root of the problem.

Using dry-powder anti-venom drugs would help avoid the storage problems associated with liquid medicines but there is a limited supply of such drugs in the country, a situation Louise finds hard to swallow. "It is a tragedy that despite producing one of the best dry-powdered anti-venom drugs and being their biggest exporter, there remains a dearth of such medicines in India," said Louise. "The manufacturers are using labour and skill from this country but are depriving people of their rights," adds Singh.

Though the government has imposed a ban on activities harmful to the reptile, conservationists feel a mere government order is not enough. They believe that a more radical approach is required. Keeping this in mind, they have come up with a solution—rehabilitating snake charmers. They are of the view that these "bare-footed conservationists" are well aware of the ecology, habitat and the different types of snakes, and so their expertise could be well used in conservation and in solving the problem of frequent snake bite cases.

Snakes have for long been known as the 'friend of farmers', helping them save their crops from the rodent population, who eat up to 20 per cent of their produce. "If there are no snakes in the fields, a substantial percentage of the crops would be destroyed by rats," explains Louise. Wildlife conservationists believe that snake charmers can be of help in educating farmers on the role the reptiles play in protecting their produce.

Treatment of snake bites may also receive a boost with the government having decided to form a protocol under the recommendations of the World Health Organisation. This will entail training of doctors, who have inadequate knowledge, to deal with the various stages of snake bite. It will also ensure fast and effective use of anti-venom drugs, besides making it available at health care centres in backward villages. It is time the government adopted this initiative as a national policy, so that both men and reptiles could be saved from the clutches of ignorance.